



Social media influencers can increase collective political beliefs and actions: findings from experiments and a quasi-experimental field study

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Abstract

The belief in the capabilities of one's own group is crucial for joining collective action aimed at addressing large-scale societal crises like climate change. Drawing from the two-step flow of communication theory and behavioral models of collective action, we conducted two experimental studies and an innovative quasi-experimental field study (total $N = 2,960$). Across these studies, influencer messages increased collective response efficacy beliefs and political action intentions, particularly among followers with strong parasocial ties. Moreover, repeated exposure to an influencer's message reinforced these effects. Our research underscores the potential of influencers in mobilizing collective political action within digital media environments.

Keywords: social media influencers, collective action, collective response efficacy, parasocial relationship, opinion leader, belief change

Public significance statement

We show that influencers can increase collective efficacy and action intentions, conditional on parasocial ties, across experiments and a field study.

Young people increasingly receive political and socially relevant information from social media influencers (Newman et al., 2025), who address issues like elections, climate change, and health (Breves & Liebers, 2022; Maares & Hanusch, 2020; Riedl et al., 2023; von Sikorski et al., 2025). Prior research showed that such content can reduce trust in public institutions and media (Harff et al., 2022) and foster political cynicism among individuals (Schmuck et al., 2022), but also inspire healthier lifestyles (Heiss & Rudolph, 2022), cultivate environmentally friendly behavior intentions, and enhance political participation (e.g., Breves & Liebers, 2022; Naderer, 2023).

Despite this growing body of work, three key research gaps remain. First, previous research predominately focused on individual-level outcomes such as personal attitudes or behavior intentions, whereas the potential to shape efficacy beliefs and action intentions on the collective level has been largely overlooked. Research on collective response efficacy—the belief that a group's actions can lead to meaningful societal or political outcomes (Jugert et al., 2016; Meijers et al., 2023)—is sparse (see Skurka et al., 2023). Collective response efficacy is distinct from individual efficacy, which refers to one's belief in their personal ability to achieve desired outcomes. This distinction is crucial, as large-scale societal challenges such as climate change cannot be addressed through individual efforts alone, but require collective political action (Fritzsche et al., 2018; van Zomeren et al., 2008), i.e., an individual's behavior aimed at improving the conditions of the entire group, such as voting or protesting.

Second, it remains unclear whether individual differences in the parasocial relationships (PSRs) with influencers shape the processing of political messages. Specifically, it is unclear if findings from influencer marketing, showing that PSR serves as a key boundary condition for persuasion (e.g., Boerman & van Reijmersdal, 2020), transfer to the political domain. Third, we lack studies that examine political messages of real lifestyle influencers and authentic followers under externally valid conditions using field study approaches.

Based on recent adaptations of the two-step flow of communication and the opinion leader framework (e.g., Harff et al., 2025), and recent models of collective action emphasizing the role of collective efficacy (e.g., Fritzsche et al., 2018), we address these research gaps using two experimental studies (Study 1, $N = 367$, Study 2, $N = 695$), and an innovative quasi-experimental field study (Study 3, $N = 1,898$). The field study was realized together with a real influencer (600,000+ followers) on Instagram and her actual followers as study participants. To the best of our knowledge, this is the first study to examine political responses from real followers of a real influencer in a quasi-experiment, which combines reception under field settings with an experimental factor.

Social media influencers as new digital opinion leaders in the political arena

In today's high choice media environments, communicators as well as channels are highly differentiated (Van Aelst et al., 2017). Social media influencers have become central actors as

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a gateway to political information (Newman et al., 2025) and are often conceptualized as (digital) opinion leaders (see e.g., Harff & Schmuck, 2023). Building on the classic two-step flow of communication, opinion leaders act as intermediaries who receive information from the media and pass it on to others. In contemporary contexts, this role extends to digitally mediated communication settings and parasocial dynamics. Stehr et al. (2015) describe media figures as *parasocial* opinion leaders, with audiences forming one-sided relationships through frequent interaction (Horton & Wohl, 1956). Harff et al. (2025) refine this view and distinguish traditional, proximal, and distant opinion leaders based on status and personalized communication. Influencers are understood as *proximal mass opinion leaders* (Harff et al., 2025) who combine high levels of self-disclosure and authenticity with a self-built public status, positioning them between traditional and distant opinion leaders. While the classic two-step flow remains relevant, in modern media environments this information flow extends into a multistep, collaborative process, in which influencers exchange information with journalists or politicians and co-create meaning with their audiences through practices of collective reciprocity—thereby reshaping opinion leadership as a multidirectional, potentially participatory process (Harff et al., 2025).

Beyond consumer topics such as beauty or travel (Hudders et al., 2021), many influencers increasingly address politics (Harff & Schmuck, 2025; von Sikorski et al., 2025), health topics (Heiss & Rudolph, 2022), and information about climate change (Dekoninck & Schmuck, 2023). Past research distinguished broadly between *lifestyle* and *political* influencers (see e.g., Harff & Schmuck, 2023), but a recently proposed typology refines this distinction along the dimensions of political content density, style, and proximity to political actors (von Sikorski et al., 2025). Of particular relevance for this study are *lifestyle-based sporadic* and *lifestyle-based politically engaged* influencers, who integrate political topics at low to moderate levels into otherwise lifestyle-oriented content. Their style is typically fact- and opinion-based, with limited proximity to parties or institutions (von Sikorski et al., 2025). Given their positioning as lifestyle-based opinion leaders who occasionally address socio-political topics, an important question is whether such influencers can also shape followers' beliefs about the collective capacity for political action.

Collective response efficacy beliefs

To understand the potential impact of influencers' political messages, it is essential to consider the role of efficacy beliefs, which refer to "the extent to which one believes an actor or action is capable of fulfilling a function" (Skurka et al., 2023, p. 116). Such beliefs are fundamental for human agency and behavior (Bandura, 2000). In the context of societal challenges such as climate change, it is not individual-level efficacy (e.g., believing one can personally reduce CO₂) that matters most, but rather collective response efficacy: individuals' confidence that their group's actions can achieve meaningful societal or political change (Meijers et al., 2023). Prior research underscores that individual action, while important, is widely regarded as insufficient for tackling systemic challenges like climate change (IPCC, 2023). Instead, societal

solutions depend critically on collective response efficacy beliefs that motivate group-based action (Fritzsche et al., 2018).

Several behavioral models emphasize collective (response) efficacy as a key driver of collective action aimed at social change (e.g., Fritzsche et al., 2018; van Zomeren et al., 2008). van Zomeren et al. (2008) focus their Social Identity Model of Collective Action (SIMCA) on public activist behavior due to perceived (or real) injustice between a politicized ingroup and an antagonistic outgroup. The Social Identity Model of Pro-Environmental Action (SIMPEA) by Fritzsche et al. (2018) differs in that the catalyst for—both public and private—behavior is an exogenous threat (i.e., climate change) instead of only intergroup injustices, and that the relevant ingroup is not necessarily politicized. Both models have in common that they highlight the key importance of collective beliefs and behavior.

While most persuasion research traditionally focuses on individual-level outcomes—such as personal attitudes, intentions, or self-efficacy—recent scholarship increasingly highlights the importance of collective-level persuasion in contexts where group-based solutions are necessary (e.g., Fritzsche et al., 2018). This distinction is particularly relevant in political communication (e.g., Lee, 2006), where messages may aim not only to change individual beliefs or behaviors, but also to shape perceptions of collective agency and solidarity. Collective-level persuasion refers to communicative efforts that target individuals' beliefs about what groups can achieve together, often by invoking a shared identity, emphasizing group norms, or highlighting the efficacy of coordinated action (Fritzsche et al., 2018; van Zomeren et al., 2008). In contrast to individual-level efficacy, which focuses on the personal ability to contribute, collective efficacy persuasion seeks to inspire belief in the broader potential of collective mobilization—an especially critical distinction in addressing large-scale issues like climate change or political reform. Indeed, recent evidence suggests that emphasizing individual-level responsibility, even when well-intentioned, can have unintended consequences (Goldwert et al., 2025): interventions designed to improve literacy around personal carbon footprints have been found to reduce support for collective climate actions, such as voting or protesting, potentially undermining broader mobilization efforts (Goldwert et al., 2025). Recognizing this difference allows for a more nuanced understanding of how media messages and influencers can foster not just personal engagement but collective empowerment.

Beyond the conceptualization of efficacy as an individual-level held belief, *efficacy information* can function as a feature of media messages through "explicitly or implicitly [conveying information] about an actor or action's capability of fulfilling a function" (Skurka et al., 2023, p. 116). In terms of collective response efficacy, such messages can emphasize, for example, that a joint protest can have positive effects on related political decisions. Prior experimental research indicates that efficacy-related messages can strengthen efficacy beliefs (e.g., Jugert et al., 2016; see also Meijers et al., 2023). In line with this, we conceptualize our stimuli not as simple cues that increase salience, but as structured messages that embed collective efficacy information into a broader narrative about climate change. This conceptualization aligns with the Integrated Model of Communication Influence on Beliefs (IMCIB; Eveland & Cooper, 2013), which suggests that

exposure to media messages—when accompanied by elaborative processing—can lead to actual changes in belief strength.

Based on theoretical models (Eveland & Cooper, 2013; Fritzsche et al., 2018; van Zomeren et al., 2008) and the initial finding by Huber et al. (2022), showing that influencers frequently share collective responsibility information in their posts about environmental topics, we theorized that when influencers incorporate collective response efficacy information in their posts (e.g., “We are strong and together we can make a real difference!”), followers’ collective response efficacy beliefs will be strengthened, as articulated in our first hypothesis (H1).

H1: Exposure to posts from an influencer containing collective response efficacy information increases participants’ collective response efficacy beliefs compared to (a) a control condition and (b) to otherwise identical posts without collective response efficacy information.

Who will be influenced by collective response efficacy information? The moderating role of PSRs with social media influencers

Influencers, conceptualized as proximal mass opinion leaders (Harff et al., 2025), have a unique ability to foster close, friendship-like bonds among their predominantly young followers. These PSRs can be seen as a central premise for explaining the differential effects of influencers in areas such as marketing, lifestyle, or politics (see e.g., Breves & Liebers, 2022). The PSR concept states that with each *parasocial interaction* (Horton & Wohl, 1956), a PSR between recipient and media persona can be dynamically initiated, intensified, or weakened, similar to interpersonal relationships (Tukachinsky & Stever, 2019). Applied to the influencer context, disclosure of personal information and regularity of communication are important facets in building and maintaining such relationships (Berryman & Kavka, 2017), making influencers appear both accessible and relatable to their audiences (Harff et al., 2025).

Previous research on influencer marketing and advertisement showed the pivotal role of PSRs in explaining their persuasive power, e.g., with regards to brand perceptions or purchase intentions (e.g., Hudders et al., 2021). This persuasive effect can be explained by various theoretical considerations and psychological mechanisms (see Breves & Liebers, 2024). Specifically, PSR may (1) function as a heuristic cue by reducing critical scrutiny (e.g., Boerman & van Reijmersdal, 2020), (2) act as a route to elaboration by enhancing personal relevance and cognitive engagement (e.g., Petty & Cacioppo, 1986) or (3) operate via social identification, where the influencer becomes part of the recipient’s in-group (Tukachinsky & Stever, 2019). While these pathways are theoretically distinct, they may overlap in practice.

Although PSR has been shown to moderate persuasive effects in marketing contexts (e.g., Boerman & van Reijmersdal, 2020), it remains an open question whether similar moderating effects occur when influencers communicate about political or socially relevant topics (Knupfer et al., 2023). This question is particularly relevant for lifestyle influencers, who predominantly build their audience through personal, lifestyle-related content but increasingly integrate political and societal issues into their communication

(Breves & Liebers, 2022; Maares & Hanusch, 2020; von Sikorski et al., 2025).

Cross-sectional studies showed that PSRs with an influencer predict political interest (Harff, 2022), perceived information quality (Cheng et al., 2024), and environmental activism (Knupfer et al., 2023). Using a panel logic, Dekoninck and Schmuck (2023) found that PSRs conditionally affect different forms of environmental participation. Experimental research revealed that followers of (real) influencers reported higher PSR levels than nonfollowers, which was associated with higher trustworthiness (Breves & Liebers, 2022). In contrast, a multiple-exposure experiment with a fictitious influencer by Harff et al. (2022) showed no moderating effect of PSR. Although this initial research yielded important findings, studies in this area often rely on fictitious sources (e.g., Harff et al., 2022) or abstract recollections of favorite influencers (e.g., Cheng et al., 2024; Dekoninck & Schmuck, 2023), raising concerns about the generalizability to real-world influencer-follower dynamics.

To address this gap, we use an experimental approach, exposing participants to political posts from real lifestyle influencers. Our aim is to examine whether PSRs moderate the effect of collective response efficacy information on recipients’ beliefs. Building on SIMPEA (Fritzsche et al., 2018), we assume that influencers function as proximal mass opinion leaders (Harff et al., 2025), who can particularly strengthen collective response efficacy beliefs among followers with a strong PSR. Based on this theorizing and previous findings (see Breves & Liebers, 2022; Dekoninck & Schmuck, 2023), we hypothesize:

H2: The effect of exposure to an influencer’s posts, including collective response efficacy information (H1), is stronger for individuals with a high level of parasocial relationship (vs. a low level) with the influencer.

The role of collective response efficacy beliefs for collective action (intentions)

In order to tackle large-scale societal challenges such as climate change (see Fritzsche et al., 2018), collective action—defined as individual behavior motivated by an ambition to improve the conditions of the entire group (van Zomeren et al., 2008)—is indispensable. Examples include voting for issue-relevant candidates, volunteering for a cause, or participating in protests (see e.g., Sabherwal et al., 2021).

Research consistently shows that individuals’ belief in their group’s collective ability to achieve desired outcomes through joint action (i.e., collective response efficacy) is a key driver of collective action (Fritzsche et al., 2018; Jugert et al., 2016; Sabherwal et al., 2021; van Zomeren et al., 2008). Especially in crisis contexts, people increasingly define themselves through group membership (“we” rather than “I”), leading them to evaluate costs and benefits from a collective perspective rather than an individual one (Fritzsche et al., 2018). Based on this theorizing, we hypothesize that collective response efficacy beliefs predict collective action intentions. Thus, H3 reads as follows:

H3: Collective response efficacy beliefs predict collective action intentions.

Taken together, our hypotheses (H1–H3) outline a sequential, theory-driven process grounded in established models of collective action and media influence (e.g., SIMCA, SIMPEA, and IMCIB). Specifically, we propose that exposure to influencer messages containing efficacy information enhances collective response efficacy beliefs (H1), that this effect is moderated by the strength of PSR (H2), and that elevated efficacy beliefs subsequently predict collective action intentions (H3). Thus, our model represents a conditional process framework (Hayes, 2022) in which communication-induced changes in efficacy belief are contingent upon parasocial ties and ultimately foster collective political action intentions.

Repeated exposure to influencer content

On social media platforms such as Instagram, users are often repeatedly exposed to persuasive media stimuli, e.g., social media posts (Bode, 2016). Such exposure can occur either intentionally (e.g., through rewatching or saving) or unintentionally (e.g., due to algorithmic recommendations or reposts from peers or the original account). In the context of influencer communication, repeated exposure may reinforce previously formed impressions and strengthen message-consistent beliefs (Koch & Zerback, 2013), particularly when the source is perceived as a parasocial friend (see Moyer-Gusé et al., 2012). Prior work also shows that repeated exposure can increase perceived credibility (the “truth effect”; Dechêne et al., 2010).

In the present context, repetition is not primarily expected to trigger deeper message elaboration or simple familiarity effects, but rather to reactivate and strengthen the impact of the initial message—thus reinforcing belief change over time. Prior work suggests that even a small number of repetitions can amplify media effects, especially when the source of the persuasive stimuli (i.e., an influencer) is perceived as being a credible communicator or even as a parasocial friend (Moyer-Gusé et al., 2012). However, such an effect cannot be clearly derived from prior research for the influence on collective response efficacy beliefs. According to Shehata et al. (2021), the development and duration of media effects in general are highly context sensitive. Therefore, we formulate the following research question with regard to repeated exposure of collective response efficacy messages disseminated by influencers:

RQ1: Does repeated exposure to an influencer’s posts including collective response efficacy information increase collective response efficacy beliefs compared to (a) no exposure at all, and (b) one-time exposure?

In addition, it remains unclear whether the strength of PSR with the influencer affects how repeated exposure is processed and perceived. On the one hand, individuals with high PSR may be especially receptive to the influencer’s message, resulting in stronger reinforcement effects across exposures. On the other hand, they may already hold strong(er) beliefs after a single exposure, making additional repetition less impactful (i.e., potential for a ceiling effect). Conversely, individuals with low PSR may be more skeptical at first, but benefit more clearly from repetition, as it provides an additional opportunity for persuasion. As we cannot be sure how potential effects of repeated exposure (RQ1) towards influencers’ posts, including collective response efficacy

information are contingent on recipients’ parasocial bond with the source, we formulate the following research question:

RQ2: Is the effect of repeated exposure on collective response efficacy beliefs moderated by the strength of parasocial relationship?

Overview of current research

We tested our hypotheses and research questions with three studies. Study 1 ($n = 367$) and Study 2 ($n = 695$) were online experiments with quota samples. In both studies, we tested our base model (H1–H3; Figure 1) in a German context. In Study 2, we used an identical design with small adjustments to the stimuli, even more targeted recruitment of participants (i.e., at least occasional Instagram user between 18 and 29 years old), and higher statistical power to test the robustness of our theoretical model via a close replication. In Study 3, we tested our model (H1–H3) and additionally investigated RQ1 (repeated exposure effect) and RQ2 (moderation of PSR) using an innovative quasi-experimental field study combined with an experimental component, which we conducted with a real and well-known influencer from Germany and her real followers ($n = 1,898$) as study participants. Study 3 (as Studies 1 and 2; #LEK-383a_r) was preregistered and received a separate full-board ethical approval from the local ethics committee (#LEK-471). We focused on the social media platform Instagram, as it is used by a majority of young people in Germany and elsewhere (see Newman et al., 2025).

An overview of model fit indices for the key regression models across all studies is provided in Table 1 (see also Table S3 for SEM-based indices approximating the full conditional process model). Overall, the values indicate an acceptable model performance in light of our data and research design.

Study 1 Method

To test our hypothesized base model (Figure 1), we conducted a between-subjects online experiment using a quota-based sample (age, gender, and education), reflecting the German population between 18 and 45 years, a preregistered decision given the relevance of social media use in this group. A total of 367 participants were recruited via the German market research company *Bilendi* (see Supp. 1.3 for detailed demographics). Participants were randomly assigned to social media posts *without* collective response efficacy information ($n = 124$), identical posts *with* collective response efficacy

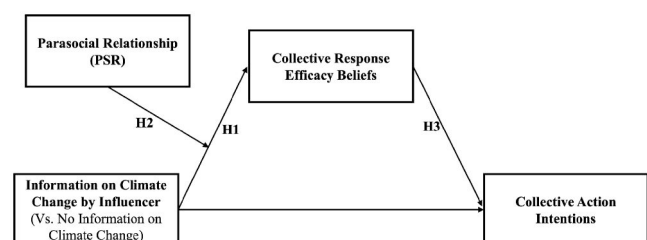


Figure 1. Hypothesized theoretical base model.

Table 1. Model fit indices for all regression models.

Study	Outcome	Parasocial relationships role	Adjusted R^2	RMSE	Sigma
Study 1	CEB	Moderator	.18	.89	.90
Study 1	CAI	n.a.	.31	.78	.79
Study 2	CEB	Moderator	.16	.88	.88
Study 2	CAI	n.a.	.25	.84	.84
Study 3	CEB	Moderator	.04	.87	.87
Study 3	CAI	n.a.	.16	.73	.73
Study 3	CEB	Covariate	.04	.87	.87
Study 3	CAI	Covariate	.18	.72	.72

Note. CAI = collective action intentions; CEB = collective response efficacy beliefs; RMSE = root mean square error; Sigma = residual standard deviation. For the models of Study 1 and 2, the control group served as the reference group; For the models of Study 3, the no-reception group served as the reference.

information ($n = 123$), or a control condition with unrelated topics ($n = 120$).

Stimulus material

All participants were exposed to two fictitious, but authentic Instagram posts allegedly shared by an influencer (see Figure S1). Following previous research (Harff et al., 2022; Naderer, 2023), we used Instagram because influencers frequently use this platform, and many young people obtain information through it (Newman et al., 2025). We used the German influencer Rezo as the source of information in both experimental conditions. Rezo is a well-known German influencer with more than 1.4 million followers on Instagram, who started with music content on YouTube, but then shifted to lifestyle topics. However, he also regularly posts content about politics and climate change, also in election contexts, reaching many first-time voters in Germany (Allgaier, 2020). In both experimental groups, participants saw two posts about the topic of climate change. Both posts addressed the urgent need for a turnaround in climate protection. Furthermore, we added information on collective response efficacy for one of the experimental groups. That is, based on the SIMPEA (Fritzsche et al., 2018), we systematically manipulated the image caption (e.g., “We are strong and together we can make a real difference!”). Thus, we obtained two stimulus versions, one *without* and one *with* collective response efficacy information, with all other information being identical.

In the control group, participants saw two unrelated posts by a fictitious influencer who posted information about spending more time with family and friends and the influencer’s great love for coffee. We deliberately decided to adjust the source (i.e., the influencer) in the control condition to prevent unintended activation of prior associations. Even exposure to unrelated posts by Rezo (even in the context of nonclimate-related topics) could have automatically activated preexisting knowledge of his climate-related content (Allgaier, 2020), which may have compromised the internal validity of the comparison. By using a fictitious influencer, we aimed to minimize this potential bias and ensure a clearer isolation of the efficacy information.

Measures

We measured *collective response efficacy beliefs* with five items based on Sabherwal et al. (2021) from 1 (Not at all) to 5 (Extremely; $M = 2.86$, $SD = .99$; $\alpha = .92$). *Collective action intentions* were measured using a 13-item scale (Sabherwal

et al., 2021; 1 = Definitely would not do, 5 = Definitely would do; $M = 2.63$, $SD = .95$; $\alpha = .94$). To measure the moderator variable, the *parasocial interaction scale* (Rubin et al., 1985) was used with adjustments to the influencer context (see Harff et al., 2022; $M = 2.56$, $SD = 1.06$, $\alpha = .93$). Although originally introduced under the label of parasocial interaction, the scale is widely recognized and applied in current research as a measure of PSRs. Dibble et al. (2016) provide empirical support for this use, concluding that the PSI scale captures central aspects of PSR and aligns well with the conceptualization of longer-term, one-sided media relationships. Example items include: “I would love to meet him/her in person” and “He/She makes me feel comfortable, like being with a friend”. Full item wordings and results of manipulation and authenticity checks are provided in the Supplemental Materials.

Results

To test our theoretical model (Figure 1), we conducted conditional process analysis (i.e., moderated mediation) using the PROCESS macro in SPSS (Hayes, 2022; Model 7; 95% bias-corrected confidence intervals based on 5,000 bootstrap iterations; Figure 2). We dummy-coded the experimental groups and used both the control condition and the baseline condition as reference groups. Collective response efficacy beliefs were modeled as a mediating variable and collective action intentions as the dependent variable. PSR (mean-centered) served as a first-stage moderator to analyze the interaction effect with our independent variables.

First, neither the results for the posts with efficacy information ($f^2 = .00$) nor the posts without efficacy information ($f^2 = .01$) showed a significant effect on collective response efficacy beliefs (vs. control condition; Figure 2). Thus, H1a was not supported. To test the effect between the two experimental groups (with and without efficacy information), we ran a separate analysis with the no efficacy group as reference (see Table S8). Again, no significant effect on collective response efficacy beliefs was found ($b = .17$, $SE = .12$, $p = .144$; $f^2 = .01$), therefore H1b was also not supported.

Looking at the interaction of PSR and the condition with efficacy information (control group as reference), a significant effect on collective response efficacy beliefs was found. This effect was not statistically robust for the group without efficacy information. The significant interaction term accounted for a 2% increase in explained variance ($F(2, 361) = 8.80$, $p = .003$; post hoc power = .85), indicating a small overall effect (Cohen, 1988). Using the pick-a-point approach (16th, 50th, and 84th percentile), we found that the posts *with* efficacy information only affected participants high in PSR (PSR = 3.63; $b = 0.51$, $SE = 0.18$, CI [0.16, 0.86]), but not those with medium (PSR = 2.63; $b = 0.18$, $SE = 0.12$, CI [−0.06, 0.41]) or low PSR (PSR = 1.25; $b = -0.28$, $SE = 0.18$, CI [−0.63, 0.07]). The Johnson–Neyman technique revealed that significant moderating effects were found for participants above a PSR of 0.27 (mean-centered), corresponding to the top 43% of the PSR distribution. In addition, we investigated the comparison of the two experimental groups (no efficacy information as reference; $f^2 = .00$) and found no significant interaction ($f^2 = .00$; see Table S8). In line with H3, results showed that collective response efficacy beliefs correlate with collective action intentions ($f^2 = .46$, indicating a large effect). We found no direct effects of our experimental conditions on collective action intentions, regardless of the

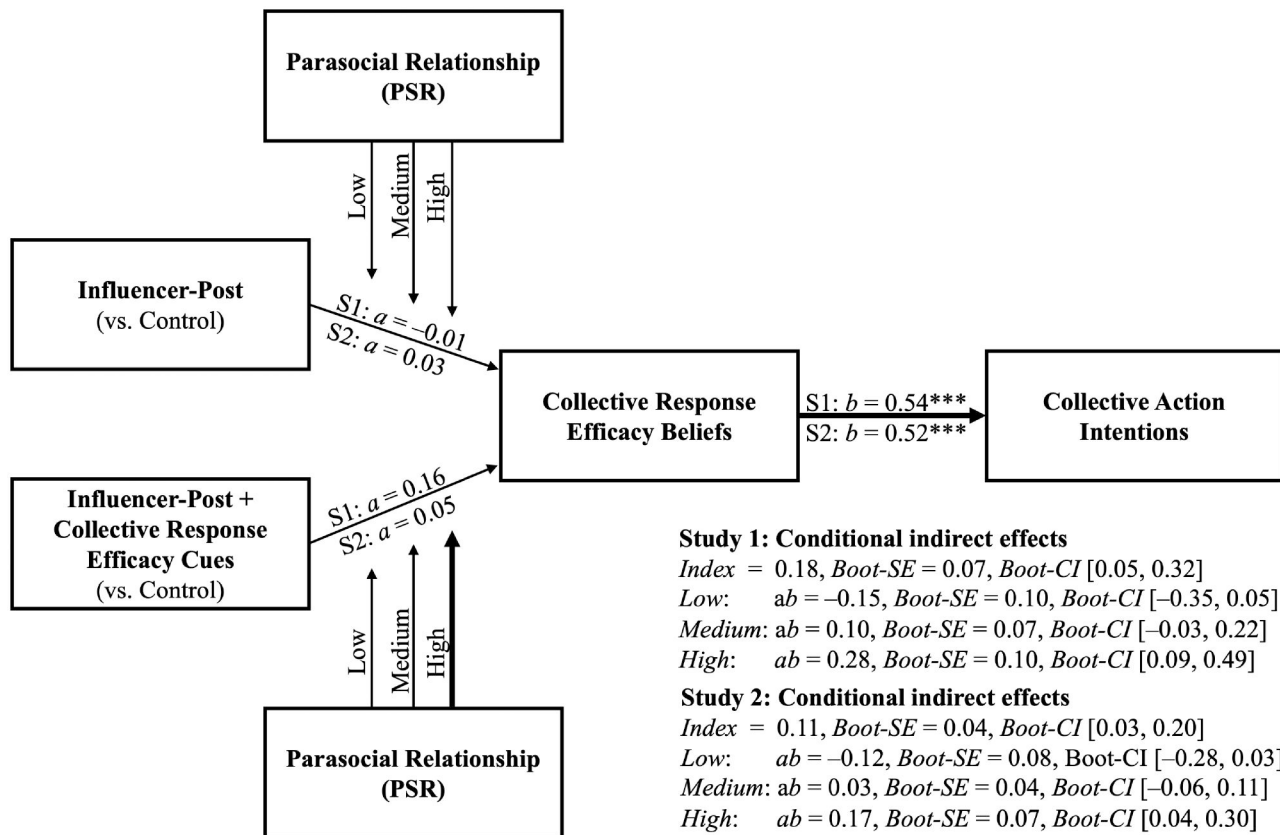


Figure 2. Results Study 1 and 2.

reference group used (f^2 statistics showed no meaningful effect sizes).

The index of moderated mediation (Hayes, 2022) confirmed that the indirect effect of efficacy information on action intentions varied as a function of PSR. Specifically, the analysis revealed a significant positive indirect effect for participants with high PSR, but not for those with medium or low PSR.

Discussion

Initial research examined how people's attitudes and behaviors are affected by the content that influencers post on social media (e.g., Schmuck et al., 2022). Our results contribute to this growing field of research. First, theoretically extending research informed by the SIMCA (van Zomeren et al., 2008), SIMPEA (Fritsche et al., 2018), and IMCIB (Eveland & Cooper, 2013), we demonstrate the pivotal function of collective response efficacy beliefs in explaining collective action intentions in a new political communication context: politically meaningful information disseminated by lifestyle influencers. Second, our results confirm an important boundary condition regarding the impact of influencers as proximal mass opinion leaders (Harff et al., 2025), revealing that effects were conditional upon an individual's level of PSR with an influencer and that only high-PSR individuals were affected. This finding corroborates and extends some initial results on the role of PSR in influencers' communication (e.g., Harff et al., 2022). Notably, the comparison between both experimental groups suggests that merely raising the issue of climate change is not sufficient to enhance collective

efficacy beliefs—even among followers with strong parasocial ties to the influencer. Only posts that explicitly conveyed collective efficacy information produced measurable belief changes, indicating the importance of message content beyond PSR. Taken together, Study 1 shows that both particular message features in influencers' posts (collective response efficacy information) and people's level of PSR are of key importance in shaping beliefs and political action intentions.

Study 2 Method

To investigate the robustness of Study 1, we conducted a close replication in Study 2. However, to better match the participants to the target audience of social media influencers, we implemented several changes. We slightly adapted our stimuli materials by modifying one of the two experimental topics, adding hashtags to the posts, and changing the depicted pictures of the influencers. Additionally, we further narrowed down the age range of our participants (18–29 years) and only included participants who use Instagram at least once a week (both preregistered decisions) to test our theoretical model with an even more typical social media-savvy sample (Newman et al., 2025). These adaptations were made to ensure that our findings were not only robust but also more applicable to the specific audience that engages with influencers on platforms like Instagram. For this study, we recruited a total of 695 participants via the German market research company *Bilendi* (see Supp. 1.3 for detailed demographics) and randomly assigned them to one of three

groups—posts *without* ($n = 231$) and *with* collective response efficacy information ($n = 231$), and control posts with unrelated topics ($n = 233$).

Stimulus material and measures

The stimuli and measures were identical to Study 1. Again, the experimental groups differed in that the group with efficacy information entailed concrete references to the effectiveness of collective action (e.g., “We must stand together and put pressure on policymakers! United! We are strong and together we can really make a difference!”). However, we changed the topic of the second post by *Rezo* and used the more relevant issue—at the time of data collection—of renewable energies. Measurements showed very good reliability.

Results

We again conducted a conditional process analysis (Hayes, 2022; Figure 2), and the groups were dummy-coded with either the control group or the baseline group as reference. First, we find no significant direct effects on collective response efficacy beliefs, irrespective of the reference group ($f^2 = .00$ and $f^2 = .01$), thus H1a and H1b were not supported. However, we find a significant moderation effect, indicating that effects are dependent on participants’ PSR. The interaction term between the condition with efficacy information and PSR accounted for a significant increase in explained variance ($\Delta R^2 = .01$, $F(2, 689) = 8.43$, $p = .004$; post hoc power = .84), suggesting a small effect size (Cohen, 1988). In line with Study 1 and H2 (pick-a-point: 16th, 50th, and 84th percentile), results showed that the posts with collective response efficacy information only affected participants high in PSR (PSR = 4.00; $b = 0.32$, $SE = 0.13$, $CI [0.07, 0.58]$), but not those with medium (PSR = 2.75; $b = 0.06$, $SE = 0.08$, $CI [-0.11, 0.22]$) or low PSR (PSR = 1.38; $b = -0.24$, $SE = 0.13$, $CI [-0.49, 0.01]$). The Johnson–Neyman technique showed significant moderating effects for participants with a mean-centered PSR above .69, corresponding to the top 28% of the PSR distribution. With regard to the group without efficacy information, the pick-a-point approach showed no significant effects, irrespective of participants’ PSR level and irrespective of the comparison (i.e., comparing the baseline both with the control group and the group with efficacy information; see Table S15).

Again, we found that collective response efficacy beliefs significantly and positively correlated with collective action intentions with a large effect size ($f^2 = .35$). No direct effects on collective action intentions were detected, irrespective of the reference group (f^2 statistics showed no meaningful effect sizes). Also, the index of moderated mediation (Hayes, 2022) confirmed that the indirect effect of efficacy information on action intentions varied as a function of PSR, with significant indirect effects only for those with a high PSR, but again not for those with medium or low PSR, supporting our conditional process model.

Discussion

The results of Study 1 were replicated in Study 2, indicating an overall robust effect. Study 2 again showed that meaningful influencer messages, including collective response efficacy information strengthened individuals’ collective response efficacy beliefs and, in turn, were associated with political collective action intentions, which was in line with our theoretical

assumptions (Eveland & Cooper, 2013; Fritzsche et al., 2018; van Zomeren et al., 2008). Once again (as in Study 1) only people with high PSR were affected (Schmuck et al., 2022). However, we do not yet know how followers react to real messages when they receive them under real conditions (actual usage situation) directly via the social media channel of an influencer. To investigate this, we conducted a conceptual replication study under field conditions in Study 3.

Study 3

Method

In this quasi-experiment, we worked with a real and well-known German influencer (600,000+ followers on Instagram) to test our theoretical model in an authentic real-life context with high external validity. The influencer generally focuses on lifestyle and fitness topics but also posts content on socio-political issues from time to time.

We used a unique research design and combined a quasi-experimental approach with a real experiment, which allowed us to examine the communication of a real influencer, reactions of real followers in a real-world field study. This hybrid approach allowed us to enhance internal validity while still capturing real-world exposure dynamics. Due to design-related differences between Studies 1 and 2 and ethical considerations, it was not possible to manipulate the presence of efficacy information and to compare it with identical messages without such information (H1b). Instead, we only tested H1a regarding the comparison between exposure to collective response efficacy information vs. no reception of such information. However, the hypotheses about the moderating role of PSR (H2) and the effect of collective response efficacy beliefs on collective action intentions (H3) could be tested as described in the theory section. The experimental factor in our design allowed us to additionally test if repeated exposure to influencer content further strengthens anticipated effects (RQ1) and how the effects of repeated exposure are dependent on followers’ PSR (RQ2).

Participants and procedure

In a first step, our cooperating influencer published an Instagram “story” (ephemeral video content on Instagram, available for 24 hr; Day 1) about the effectiveness of the collective in fostering systemic change through collective climate action (described below). After the video became unavailable (24 hr), the influencer shared the link to our survey via her Instagram channel with more than 600,000 followers through another Instagram story (on Day 2). In this story, the influencer encouraged her followers to participate in our survey (without compensation or incentives). In total, we recruited 1,898 participants (94.5% female; $M_{age} = 30.07$, $SD = 7.76$). Among all completed interviews, 90.5% reported that they follow the influencer account. The data were collected in mid-April 2023. Participants provided informed consent and answered questions regarding their PSR with the influencer and about whether they had seen the “climate story” on the influencer’s Instagram account (the day before; Day 1). People who reported they had seen the story additionally received specific recall questions to verify they had indeed seen the story (Supp 4.1) and were then randomly assigned to condition 1 (no “climate story” reception) or condition 2 (reception of the “climate story” inside the survey).

The combination of a quasi-experiment (self-selected exposure) and a real experiment (randomized exposure) allowed us to comprehensively investigate the effects of influencer communication across different contexts and levels of exposure. Specifically, we examined: (1) the impact of one-time exposure versus no exposure to the influencer's message, (2) the differences between message reception in a natural setting on Instagram versus a more controlled survey environment, and (3) the potential additive effects of repeated exposure, with the message being viewed both on Instagram and in the survey. These comparisons are crucial for understanding not only the immediate effects of influencer communication but also how these effects may vary across different viewing conditions and over time. As depicted in Figure 3, this led to four distinct groups: No reception of "climate story" ($n = 723$), reception of "climate story" on Day 1 in real-world setting on Instagram ($n = 282$), reception of "climate story" on Day 2 in our survey ($n = 669$) and reception of "climate story" both on Day 1 and Day 2 in our survey-experiment ($n = 224$).

Stimulus material

The 2-min video (consisting of two linked Instagram stories) showed the influencer in a frontal shot, speaking directly into the camera (see Supp 4.2 for the full transcript). In the "climate story," the influencer talks about a recent discussion she had about the new IPCC report on climate change, stressing that small (individual) changes are insufficient to tackle the issue, and that collective action is needed (e.g., to persuade politicians and policymakers to act on climate change). Also, the influencer included both collective response efficacy information (e.g., "I think it's important [...] that we all start pulling together, because then we can really make a difference") and information on collective action (e.g., "... it depends on who we elect ... politicians must act. And for politics to act, we simply must elect the respective politicians") in the story. Participants within the survey-reception

groups were exposed to the exact same story (Day 1) in the survey (Day 2; the continue button was not displayed until after the end of the video to ensure that it was seen completely).

Measures

The central constructs were measured in exactly the same way as in Studies 1 and 2 and showed very good reliability (Supp. 1.3 for measures and 4.3 for manipulation and randomization checks).

Results

We investigated whether our findings from Studies 1 and 2 can be replicated in the real-world context, using the PROCESS macro in SPSS (Hayes, 2022; Model 7; Figure 4). The no-reception group served as the main reference group for our dummy variables. First, answering H1, we find significant effects of our reception groups on collective response efficacy beliefs (one-time reception Day 1, Instagram: $b = .19$, $SE = .06$, $p = .004$, $f^2 = .01$; one-time reception Day 2, Survey: $b = .26$, $SE = .05$, $p < .001$, $f^2 = .02$; two-time reception: $b = .40$, $SE = .07$, $p < .001$, $f^2 = .02$) with small effect sizes. Comparing both one-time reception groups, results revealed no significant differences ($f^2 = .00$). In addition, we compared the two-time reception group with both other reception groups and found significant differences with small effect sizes (reception on Instagram: $b = .22$, $SE = .08$, $p = .008$, $f^2 = .01$; reception in our survey: $b = .14$, $SE = .07$, $p = .037$, $f^2 = .00$; see Supp. 4.4 for all regression tables), answering RQ1.

Looking at PSR as the first stage moderator (no reception as reference), the interaction terms jointly accounted for a significant but small increase in explained variance ($\Delta R^2 = .01$, $F(2, 1890) = 3.16$, $p = .024$; post hoc power analysis = .97), with no significant effect for the one-time reception group on Instagram and for the two-time reception group. However, there is a significant interaction for participants exposed to

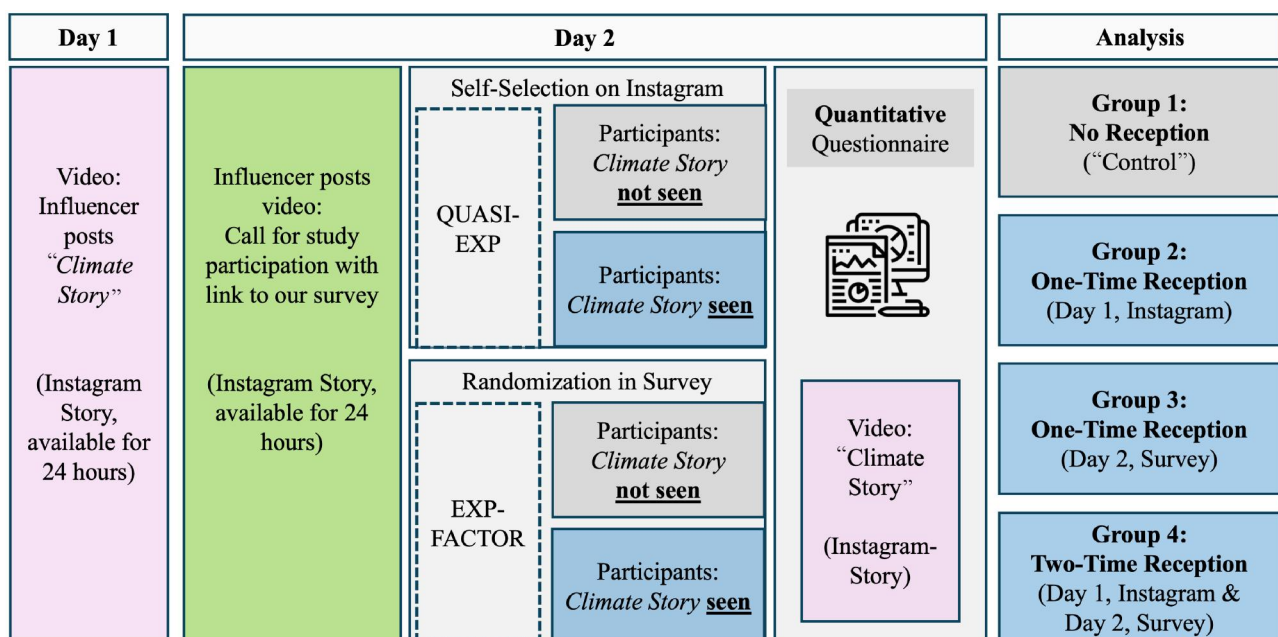


Figure 3. Overview method Study 3.

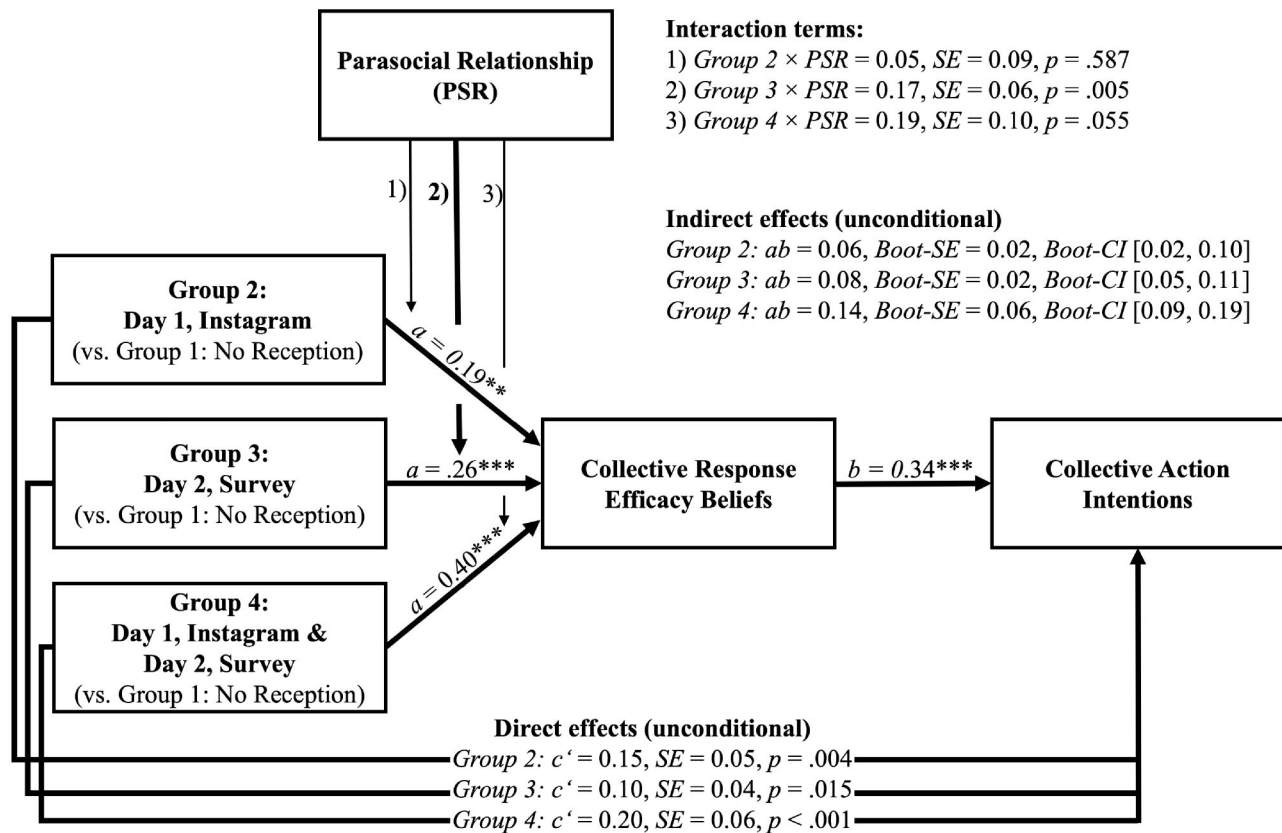


Figure 4. Results study 3.

Note. When not indicated otherwise, results represent coefficients obtained from PROCESS Model 7 (moderated mediation); Unconditional direct and indirect effects were obtained from PROCESS Model 4 (simple mediation, PSR as covariate); bold lines indicate significant effects.

the ‘Climate Story’ one-time in our survey on Day 2 ($f^2 = .01$). Further investigating the 16th, 50th, and 84th percentile, we find significant conditional effects for all levels of PSR on collective response efficacy beliefs (PSR *low* = 3.25: $b = .15, SE = .06, p = .014$; PSR *middle* = 4.00: $b = .27, SE = .05, p < .001$; PSR *high* = 4.75: $b = .40, SE = .07, p < .001$). For this significant interaction, the Johnson–Neyman technique showed significant effects for participants with a mean-centered PSR above $-.80$, corresponding to the top 85% of the PSR distribution. Using either the one-time reception group on Instagram or the reception in our survey as reference, no additional interaction terms became significant (see Supp. 4.4). In addition, the effect of repeated exposure on collective response efficacy beliefs was not moderated by participants’ PSR (RQ2). Thus, we can fully confirm H1 regarding the effects of efficacy information on collective response efficacy beliefs and partly confirm H2 (moderating effect of PSR only for the one-time reception in our survey). As in Studies 1 and 2, we find that collective response efficacy beliefs positively correlated with collective action intentions (with a medium effect size $f^2 = .17$), confirming H3.

As only the interaction term for the one-time survey reception group was found significant, we ran another analysis with PSR as covariate, to investigate potential unconditional indirect effects (PROCESS, Model 4; Figure 4; for analysis of variance-based analyses see Supp. 4.5). Here, we find significant indirect effects for all reception groups on collective action intentions via collective response efficacy beliefs (see Table S27). Furthermore, results revealed significant direct effects for all reception groups (vs. no reception) on collective

action intentions ($f^2 = .01$ for the one-time reception groups and $f^2 = .02$ for the two-time reception group). In addition, we find a significant direct effect of the two-time reception group compared to one-time reception in our survey ($f^2 = .01$).

Discussion

Study 3 aimed to conceptually replicate the results from the first two studies with a quasi-experiment, which was combined with an experimental component. For the first time, the results show that the effects are robust under field conditions and when a message is directly disseminated to followers by a real influencer (on Instagram). The general pattern of the first two studies is again evident. Influencer information on climate change with collective response efficacy information strengthens collective response efficacy and indirectly related to collective political action, in line with previous theorizing (e.g., Fritzsche et al., 2018). In contrast to the first two studies, Study 3 shows main effects on collective response efficacy, which can be explained by the consistently high level of PSR among the participants (mostly followers; $M_{PSR} = 3.92$, scale from 1 to 5; see Supp 1.3).

Likely due to the quasi-experimental approach with many followers as participants, the overall variance of PSR was relatively small. Together with the unequal group sizes and the associated differing power of the interaction analyses, this may explain the varying significance of the interaction effects. In addition, the mean PSR scores for the no reception and the one-time survey condition were somewhat lower compared to both other conditions, with a slightly higher standard

deviation. For this significant interaction term, the variance of PSR was higher compared to all other investigated interaction terms. This may help explain why only the one-time survey condition showed a significant moderation. Unlike exposure on Instagram, the survey environment was more controlled and cognitively focused, potentially prompting more deliberate message processing. This context might have amplified the role of PSR as a moderator, especially among participants with greater variation in their perceived relationship to the influencer.

However, this has no influence on the overall results. Rather, this once again underlines the central importance of PSR for the persuasive power of influencers and is generally in line with the results of Studies 1 and 2. In contrast to Studies 1 and 2, Study 3 also shows direct effects on collective action. One explanation for this finding is that the influencer (unlike in Studies 1 and 2) additionally addressed the need for collective political action in her post. While we cannot isolate the exact elements responsible for this effect—partly due to the relatively long and multifaceted material used—the inclusion of such action-oriented content is a plausible contributor. This interpretation aligns with prior theorizing (Fritzsche et al., 2018) and should be directly tested in future studies using more controlled manipulations of action versus efficacy information (see also Berkebile-Weinberg et al., 2024).

Another key finding from Study 3 is that the observed effects may be further amplified through repeated exposure—at least in people with substantial levels of PSR. Our operationalization involved showing participants the exact same video message on two consecutive days, reflecting typical exposure dynamics on social media (e.g., algorithmic recommendations, or deliberate rewatching). While this setup captures certain real-world patterns, the short interval limits conclusions about longer-term reinforcement. Still, the results align with theoretical perspectives on repeated exposure (Koch & Zerback, 2013) and the truth effect (Dechêne et al., 2010), which suggest that message repetition increases perceived validity via enhanced processing fluency. Compared to single exposure, repeated contact with persuasive content may therefore more strongly shape efficacy beliefs and action intentions. Similarly, Shehata et al. (2021) argue that repeated exposure can influence belief trajectories more sustainably than isolated messages, highlighting the dynamic nature of belief updating. Future research should explore how different exposure frequencies and message variations interact to either reinforce or reshape political attitudes over time and help disentangle the temporal and causal dynamics behind these effects, especially with regard to collective-level efficacy beliefs and action intentions.

General discussion

In today's rapidly changing high-choice media environments (Van Aelst et al., 2017), people rely increasingly (some entirely) on social media and influencers for (political) information. Our research makes a theoretical and a methodological contribution both to the literature in (political) communication and emerging research on the impact of meaningful political messages disseminated by influencers who focus on lifestyle topics.

The results from three studies—two online experiments and one quasi-experimental field study with an experimental

factor—consistently show that influencers act as persuasive proximal mass opinion leaders (Harff et al., 2025) and influence followers not only in terms of recipients' *individual* beliefs, attitudes, and behavior (e.g., Breves & Liebers, 2022; Harff et al., 2022; Schmuck et al., 2022), but also on recipients' beliefs and behavioral intentions that are related to the *collective* level. Serious societal challenges, such as climate change, which are increasingly being addressed by influencers (Dekoninck & Schmuck, 2023), require action at a collective level and can only be solved effectively if, in addition to individual action, societies and social groups work together and individuals believe in the effectiveness of such collective endeavors (Fritzsche et al., 2018). While the persuasiveness of influencer communication and the relevance of PSR as a boundary condition have been well established in marketing contexts (e.g., Boerman & van Reijmersdal, 2020), there has only been preliminary evidence that this moderating influence transfers to the realm of politics (e.g., Breves & Liebers, 2022; Dekoninck & Schmuck, 2023), even when (fictitious) lifestyle-focused influencers refer to such topics (see also Naderer, 2023). The present studies demonstrate that lifestyle influencers can take on an important mediation function in increasingly fragmented media environments (Van Aelst et al., 2017), which extends beyond marketing contexts, as influencers reach young people who rarely (or never) use traditional news media (see Newman et al., 2025).

Our demonstration that influencers can shape collective response efficacy beliefs and collective action intentions represents a new and central finding that extends key theoretical frameworks of collective action. Building on SIMPEA (Fritzsche et al., 2018), which highlights that such beliefs may also arise outside politicized group contexts, our results provide empirical evidence that lifestyle influencers—conceptualized as proximal mass opinion leaders (Harff et al., 2025; see also von Sikorski et al., 2025)—can indeed strengthen efficacy beliefs through mediated communication. Thus, our research makes an important theoretical contribution by integrating and expanding theoretical models of (proenvironmental) collective action (Fritzsche et al., 2018; van Zomeren et al., 2008) and belief change (Eveland & Cooper, 2013) with the two-step flow of communication and the digital opinion leader concept (Harff et al., 2025; Schmuck et al., 2022) and by testing this integrated and extended model in an influencer communication context (see Levine & Markowitz, 2024). Our findings show that the “second step” of the two-step flow in digital contexts is relationship-dependent: effects on collective response efficacy beliefs and related collective action intentions occur primarily among followers with stronger parasocial bonds. This pattern refines recent extensions of the opinion leader framework that conceptualize social media influencers as proximal mass opinion leaders (Harff et al., 2025). Their persuasive impact does not derive from reach alone but hinges on personalized communication and relational proximity, thereby sharpening the explanatory scope of the two-step flow tradition for contemporary digital media environments. Future research should more systematically explore how contemporary digital opinion leadership may involve reciprocal or multistep dynamics beyond dyadic communication structures (see Lou, 2022).

Beyond questions of informational flows, future research should also attend to the content and framing of efficacy information. Future research should compare the effects of individual, collective, and institutional efficacy information

and beliefs (see Skurka et al., 2023) and investigate other important predictors for collective action intentions, such as ingroup norms and goals or ingroup identifications (see Fritzsche et al., 2018). In addition, future studies should also aim to control for potential confounding variables, such as message length, which differed slightly between conditions in Studies 1 and 2 due to the inclusion or exclusion of collective efficacy information. Notably, while differences across experimental conditions were significant and theoretically meaningful, the overall means for collective response efficacy beliefs and collective action intentions were relatively low—often below the scale midpoint (i.e., 3)—regardless of condition. This pattern suggests a generally low baseline belief in the effectiveness of collective political action among participants and warrants further investigation. Although the observed effects were small, they remain substantively meaningful, as even modest shifts in followers' beliefs can scale and mobilize audiences (e.g., through resharing online and when followers themselves act as opinion leaders within their own peer groups). Importantly, these effects emerged after only limited exposure (one or two posts) in studies using a real influencer and actual PSRs—with Study 3 combining a field setting with an experimental factor—suggesting that even minimal interventions can activate the mechanisms proposed by collective action models in digital opinion leadership contexts.

Another theoretical contribution of the present studies is the systematic analysis of the boundary conditions of influencers' impact, which advances our understanding of influencer communication in regard to *who* is influenced by their messages (see Levine & Markowitz, 2024). Influencers have been conceptualized as proximal mass opinion leaders (Schmuck et al., 2022) and important role models (Maares & Hanusch, 2020), who can stimulate learning processes and the imitation of actions, especially in young people (Bandura, 2001). Our results demonstrate that there are clear limitations with regard to the persuasive power of influencers. Only people with a strong parasocial bond to an influencer can be influenced in their views and intention to act. Using influencers with a focus on lifestyle topics, we show that the persuasive power of strong parasocial ties extends to topics that are rather unlikely (i.e., political) for these sources. This finding corroborates and extends initial results (e.g., Dekoninck & Schmuck, 2023; Naderer, 2023) and is in line with the conceptualization of influencers as proximal mass opinion leaders (Harff et al., 2025). Since PSR was measured rather than manipulated, the moderation results should be interpreted with some caution. While this approach provides ecologically valid insights into the role of naturally existing parasocial bonds, future studies could strengthen causal claims by experimentally manipulating PSR. Additionally, future research should further explore the role of trust and source credibility in influencer communication, using differentiated and theory-driven measurement approaches to complement PSR.

In addition, the results from Study 3 show that the effect of PSR under real conditions and in communication between a real influencer and real followers appears to be even stronger than previously assumed. Likely due to the overall high PSR values among the participants (most of them followers), the "influence threshold" was exceeded on average for all of them. Moreover, we showed a trend in the data that even higher PSR values make the effects even greater (even if only

the interaction term with the greatest statistical power became significant). Given that over 90% of Study 3 participants followed the influencer, many likely shared her values, limiting the generalizability to audiences with different prior attitudes.

Our findings clarify some inconsistent results (e.g., Harff et al., 2022) of previous studies in which PSR was measured at more abstract levels or in the context of fictitious influencers, and thus show that the influence of PSR with regard to communication about sociopolitical issues was partly empirically underestimated. While the PSR concept was originally related to pure asymmetric relations (Horton & Wohl, 1956), more recent theoretical adaptations adjusted the concept to digitally mediated communication environments and the inherent affordances by integrating potential interactions between media person and recipient (see Lou, 2022). Future studies should further elaborate and empirically test these nuanced differences in how such relations between follower and influencer are built, maintained, and intensified (Tukachinsky & Stever, 2019), particularly with regard to political influence. Moreover, future research should examine through which psychological mechanisms PSR exerts its influence. Possible pathways include heuristic cues, increased message elaboration due to personal relevance, or processes of social identification—each of which may be differentially activated depending on message type, audience characteristics, and communication context. With regard to the operationalization, further development of refined and context-specific PSR measurement instruments—particularly for the influencer domain—represents an important avenue for future research, especially given the conceptual and empirical challenges outlined by Dibble et al. (2016). In addition, our findings contribute to a better understanding of politically relevant communication by lifestyle influencers who only sporadically or occasionally address political issues—a group that remains understudied but may be particularly valuable in reaching politically disengaged or hard-to-reach audiences. Future studies should further investigate the potential to mobilize followers with regard to different influencer types (see von Sikorski et al., 2025) and different audience segments.

Furthermore, the present study makes an important contribution from a methodological perspective and shows possibilities for investigating the communication of influencers and the corresponding effects on actual followers with high external validity. We hope that this new methodological approach—collaborating with a real influencer—will encourage other researchers to develop similar methodological approaches (or use the present one) in order to gain an even better understanding of influencer communication.

Finally, we—for the first time—analyzed a repeated exposure paradigm in connection with exposure to an influencer's audiovisual content. Results show that repeated use of the identical influencer content leads to the effects described being further intensified. This confirms previous research informed by a repeated exposure paradigm (Koch & Zerback, 2013) and the truth effect (Dechêne et al., 2010) and extends these theoretical accounts to the communication of influencers. However, we only examined this effect in Study 3 and are therefore cautious in interpreting this result. Nevertheless, we hope that this first finding will motivate more research on the effects of repeated exposure to influencer messages, as it seems plausible that followers (with high PSR) may expose themselves to certain influencer

content several times and not only once (see Bode, 2016). Another limitation of the present studies is that we examined no long-term effects and cannot say how long the detected effects last (see Shehata et al., 2021). Also, the present studies examined effects in the German context. Although we are convinced that the general pattern of our results should be demonstrable in other cultural contexts, future studies need to test this systematically.

Conclusion

Young people increasingly receive political and socially relevant information from social media influencers. We examine how these messages affect young people's collective political beliefs and action intentions and report results from three studies—two experiments and one field study together with a real influencer and her real followers. The results show that politically meaningful influencer communication is only effective when a strong PSR is already in place. In this sense, PSR appears to be a necessary precondition for influencer messages to impact collective efficacy beliefs and, indirectly, collective action intentions. Furthermore, the results show that repeated exposure to an influencer's video post reinforces these effects further. Influencers can thus be influential political opinion leaders and influence followers—who have established a close PSR with an influencer—in their collective political views and action intentions.

Supplementary material

Supplementary material is available at *Human Communication Research* online.

Data availability

Data, materials and preregistrations are available at <https://osf.io/43xzf>.

Author contributions

Pascal Merz (Conceptualization, Formal Analysis, Investigation, Methodology, Visualization, Writing—original draft, Writing—review & editing) and Christian von Sikorski (Conceptualization, Investigation, Methodology, Funding acquisition, Project administration, Supervision, Writing—original draft, Writing—review & editing).

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Conflicts of interest

The authors declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

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Ethical considerations

The local Ethics Review Committee for the Department of Psychology at the University of Kaiserslautern-Landau (RPTU) approved our studies (Study 1 and 2: #LEK-383a_r, January 2022; Study 3: #LEK-471, May 2023).

Consent to participate

Respondents gave written (informed) consent in our online questionnaire by clicking a check box, ensuring that they were older than 18 years and that they received all relevant information for our study (i.e., anonymity, voluntariness, data protection, and contact information of the study coordinator).

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